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Gross National Happiness?

Bhutan, the last surviving Buddhist kingdom in the Himalayas, more than any other country in the world epitomizes the myth of Shangri-la. A small country with less than a million people, squeezed between the two most populous countries on Earth which are also regional rivals, Bhutan has managed to retain its distinctive cultural identity. Its landscape is breathtakingly spectacular, with ancient Buddhist monasteries scattered on the mountain tops, and, it was as a commitment to build a nation based on Buddhist spiritual values rather than crass materialism that King Jigme Singye Wangchuk coined the term Gross National Happiness (GNH) in the early 1970s. The country's national anthem, adopted in 1953, was written to sum up the spirit of a society that 'sprung from an aboriginal people and was enriched by Tibetan, Mongol, and Indo-Burman migrants'[1]:

> In the Thunder Dragon Kingdom adorned with sandalwood
> The protector who guards the teachings of the dual systems
> He, the precious glorious ruler, causes dominions to spread
> While his unchanging position abides in constancy
> As the doctrine of the Lord Buddha flourishes
> May the sun and peace and happiness shine on the people![2]

Buddhism has long been the state religion of Bhutan and the 'dual systems' refers to the combination and, until the early twentieth century, division, of civil as well as spiritual rule that throughout history has characterized the country's rather unique governance structure. But behind this romanticized and picturesque facade lies a turbulent past and a precarious present. Following several conflicts between Britain's colonial power in India and the Bhutanese, an agreement was reached in 1910 whereby Bhutan submitted 'to be guided by the advice of the British